

Europe braces for a deadly hybrid attack

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Presented by Amazon By GERARDO FORTUNA with NICHOLAS VINOCUR and ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna, fresh from getting a new addition

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna, fresh from getting a new addition to my collection of political memorabilia in Strasbourg: a miniature of the 2.5-meter-tall statue unveiled in Parliament yesterday depicting a naked Donald Trump, golf club in hand, sitting on the back of a smaller man. It could even rival my Rubik's Cube featuring Manfred Weber's face from the 2019 European People's Party Spitzenkandidat race.

In today's Playbook:

— Britain wants to be part of "Made in Europe" — but it's not discussing matching the EU's tariffs on Chinese EVs.

— The polarization in the European Parliament is spilling over into Strasbourg's nightlife.

— Faces in the crowd: Hamish Falconer, Oana Lungescu, Iratxe García, Terry Reintke, Rima Hassan, Elif Eralp, Kaja Kallas, Kemi Badenoch, Nicolae Ciucă and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack why the EU is quietly planning how it would respond to a Russian attack on its soil — and what that says about NATO.

**A message from Amazon: Businesses across Europe are using the AWS Cloud to modernise essential industries. In Valmacca, Italy, xFarm uses cloud technology to help farmers make data-driven decisions, improve productivity, and support more sustainable agricultural practices—connecting farms across Europe and beyond. Hear from more AWS customers across Europe. **

DRIVING THE DAY

EUROPE BRACES FOR A DEADLY HYBRID ATTACK — AND DEBATES WHO SHOULD RESPOND: EU capitals are quietly preparing for a major hybrid attack that kills several people — an outcome that looks

increasingly likely, five EU diplomats and officials told Nick Vinocur . But the discussions have exposed divisions over how far the bloc should go on security, and whether its role would duplicate NATO's.

Nightmare scenario: Ambassadors from all 27 EU countries have held confidential talks in recent weeks in a "restricted format," without phones or assistants, including a meeting last Wednesday that focused specifically on attacks causing mass casualties, two diplomats said. The diplomats were granted anonymity to discuss the confidential exchanges.

Discussions have intensified since an explosive-laden drone was found at Leipzig airport in August. While the EU has long had a "hybrid toolbox" for coordinating responses to cyberattacks, election interference and sabotage, the latest talks have considered emergency response teams, freeing up EU funds for an affected country and how EU leaders should communicate.

"We have to be prepared for something serious," a senior EU diplomat said. "Unfortunately, Leipzig showed us that a very serious incident, something that causes multiple casualties, is not out of the question."

Rising danger: The EU says Russia has stepped up cyberattacks, sabotage and other covert operations since its full-scale invasion of Ukraine. On Tuesday, sailors were reported missing after drones struck two ships in the Black Sea . "Given the scope and scale of Russia's action there are bound to be casualties sooner than later," a second EU official said. "It's sheer luck there haven't been any yet."

Some capitals fear the EU is overreaching on security and duplicating NATO, which has underpinned European security for nearly 80 years. "If there is confusion or duplication, that risks slowing down the decision-making," said Oana Lungescu, a former NATO spokesperson.

Several diplomats are also worried that sensitive information shared in EU meetings could leak. "It either shows up in the media or goes straight to Moscow," said a diplomat from an eastern flank state.

Commission President Ursula von der Leyen has proposed an "emergency security protocol" and a "European Security Council," with both expected to feature in a European Security Strategy due early November. Some diplomats say new structures could take months to establish and overlap with existing tools. "We already have mechanisms in place," one senior national diplomat said, pointing to the EU's crisis response system, IPCR.

Putin doesn't care: NATO should handle intelligence-sharing and military deterrence, while the EU focuses on civilian response, Lungescu said. But Moscow makes no distinction between the institutions: "Frankly, [Russian President Vladimir] Putin doesn't care whether decisions are taken by Coreper 2 or the NAC," she said, referring to meetings of EU ambassadors or NATO's decision-making body.

BIG AND BREAKING

GREENS STAY THE COURSE: The Greens kicked off a season of midterm leadership appointments in the European Parliament by picking Terry Reintke and Nicu Kretzaru as their new top duo , promising more energetic campaigning but no U-turn on the group's political direction.

BERLIN'S MAMDANI MOMENT: Elif Eratp could become Berlin's next mayor — if she can overcome concerns about antisemitism and convince Jewish Berliners to trust the Left.

KALLAS IN BEIRUT: EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas lands in Lebanon today for a two-day visit to pave the way for a new EU mission to train and advise the country's armed forces, while pushing Beirut

on financial and judicial reforms.

Kallas told Playbook exclusively that she expects EU foreign ministers to formally establish the new mission on Monday, adding: “The mission will make a crucial contribution to Lebanon’s security.” She’ll also oversee an EU-funded equipment handover and visit Beirut’s port.

BREXIT RESET PITCH

BRITAIN WANTS A PIECE OF “MADE IN EUROPE”: The U.K. wants its goods to count as European under the EU’s proposed new industrial rules, its Brexit minister Hamish Falconer told Playbook’s Zoya Sheftalovich — but he dismissed reports that London is discussing matching the bloc’s tariffs on Chinese electric cars.

Falconer is in Strasbourg today to meet European Parliament President Roberta Metsola and Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič, making his pitch for a closer relationship ahead of a U.K.-EU summit penciled in for next month.

“A straightforward and unfussy arrangement” is what the EU and U.K. should aim for, avoiding new barriers for British and European companies, Falconer said.

The EU’s “Made in Europe” plan would give preference to goods made in the bloc in some public contracts and support programs. The U.K. wants British industry included, with Falconer arguing that supply chains already cross the Channel: “For Europe to be more competitive and able to weather some of the shocks that we’re all talking about, we need to do it together.”

What does Britain have to offer in return? “The prime minister’s been absolutely clear that he is ambitious, and those are the instructions that I am under — to be ambitious, to look at all of the options,” Falconer told Zoya. He added that Andy Burnham would say more in a set-piece speech closer to the summit. Burnham “thinks the status quo doesn’t work well,” Falconer said. “It doesn’t work well, I think, for the U.K., and it doesn’t work well for the EU.”

On China: Falconer pushed back on the idea that Brussels was demanding that the U.K. slap tariffs on Chinese electric cars, saying he was “surprised” to have read those reports. “That’s not the kind of conversation that I’m having with my European counterparts,” he said. Falconer argued the U.K. is “not a backdoor for goods” and has “very robust arrangements” in place. The two sides should tackle shared challenges, he said, “but let us not do harm to our collective industrial base.”

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni has applied to the European Union Intellectual Property Office to trademark her voice ... but what is the EUIPO? Based in Alicante, Spain, it’s an EU agency responsible for managing intellectual property rights that are valid across the bloc, as well as trademarks and EU designs. It used to be known as the Office for Harmonization in the Internal Market.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked for your spy novel recommendations. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

FRANCE VS. EVERYONE

COUNCIL TUSSLES OVER WHO GETS DEFENSE CASH: Today will see the latest flashpoint between France and other EU governments over whether countries from outside the bloc, such as Canada, Ukraine and the U.K., can access defense funding in the next seven-year budget, Gregorio Sorigi reports.

The discussion among EU ambassadors is crucial for Paris, which argues that access to the planned €131 billion of defense funds should be limited to EU companies. It is clashing with a bloc of countries, including Germany and Italy, that insist defense firms from allied countries should be able to access the money.

Ambassadors will discuss a compromise put forward by the Irish presidency of the Council of the EU, obtained by POLITICO's Marianne Gros, that envisions the participation of foreign countries that sign an association agreement with the EU.

LE PEN'S BUDGET THREAT: Far-right presidential frontrunner Marine Le Pen has unveiled plans to halve France's net contributions to the EU budget from around €10 billion to €5 billion — a frightening prospect for EU governments wary that they might have to fill the gap if she wins the election next spring.

To reduce national contributions, Le Pen suggested harmonizing tobacco and alcohol taxes across Europe and transferring the revenues to the Brussels budget. She also proposed linking national budget contributions to carbon emissions.

Reality check: The ideas are unlikely to be accepted by Northern states wary of expanding the EU's taxing powers and by countries with carbon-intensive industries, like Poland.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

AI LIABILITY ... REMEMBER THAT? The EU shelved its rules on AI liability — but now OpenAI chief Sam Altman has revived the debate.

TRUMP WEIGHS IN: Donald Trump has blamed the wave of student protests in France on "out of control mass migration" and Islam (neither of which spurred the demonstrations).

Meanwhile ... Trump told reporters last night he'll have a call with Vladimir Putin to discuss Russia's suspected plague case "very soon," the Associated Press reports.

PERSONA NON GRATA: Latvia has moved to boot out Russian journalist Leonid Ragozin after he was accused of making pro-Kremlin comments on a podcast, Ali Walker writes.

FLAG FIGHT: France Unbowed MEP Rima Hassan accused Parliament President Roberta Metsola of making "factually false" claims that Israeli and EU flags were knocked over at an exhibition marking the Oct. 7 attacks.

AMENDMENT AVALANCHE: More than 4,000 amendments to the Industrial Accelerator Act land today — and the EPP may have a bombshell among them, my colleagues report in Morning Fair Play (for subscribers).

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny spells turning to rain by the evening. High of 23C.

STARTING IN STRASBOURG ... Yes, I know this is Brussels Corner. But your Playbook author is in Strasbourg. Wednesday here is basically Thursday in Brussels: one last night out before everyone leaves. But even the nightlife can't escape political polarization.

Right turn: The American-style bar Les Aviateurs, which keeps going until 4 a.m., has increasingly become a right-wing haunt. The trend has been building for a while, and several Parliament officials and assistants said it is no longer a hangout if you're not part of the EPP or ECR.

The Socialists, meanwhile, have been colonizing Aedaen Place, also known as "the speakeasy." The Greens sometimes go there too, although some have migrated to Le Hoop.

Left splits at night: France Unbowed MEPs and staffers head almost religiously to Petit Tigre every Wednesday. But Italy's Five Star Movement, the second-biggest delegation in the Left group, is more itinerant, with Boucanier a favorite — partly for the carpaccio à volonté. Vegetarians get a mysterious half-pizza, half-salad creation (thoughts and prayers with my fellow Italians).

FOR THOSE WHO STAYED IN BRUSSELS: Don't worry, we haven't forgotten you.

Tintinology 101: Brussels today launches the international symposium "Les cultures de Tintin — Objectif centenaire," beginning the countdown to Tintin's 100th birthday in 2029. There's even a "Tintinophile" walk through central Brussels, meeting outside City Hall at 10 a.m. and departing a half-hour later.

Serious Tintin business: At 4 p.m., proceedings move to the Palais des Académies for talks on Hergé's Brussels legacy, including a roundtable with cartoonists Philippe Geluck and Pierre Kroll. It's free, but registration is required.

Also tonight: The 39th Tels Quels Festival opens at Les Grands Carmes at 8 p.m. with an improv show, kicking off 10 days of drag, film, slam, debates and queer culture.

FLYING FRIDAY? GOOD LUCK: Brussels Airlines is canceling around four in 10 flights to and from Brussels Airport on Friday because of disruption at ground handler Alyzia, Belga news agency reports . Around 140 flights operated by airlines using the company are being scrapped. Consider this your early warning to check before heading to Zaventem.

SPOTTED ... at POLITICO's party in Madrid launching the latest addition to our Playbook family (sign up for Madrid Playbook here): Spain's Health Minister Mónica García; Inclusion Minister Elma Saiz; Interior Minister Fernando Grande-Marlaska; Equality Minister Ana Redondo García; Third Deputy Prime Minister and Ecological Transition Minister Sara Aagesen; Secretary of State for Energy Joan Groizard; deputy chief of staff to the prime minister Ángel Alonso; Catalonia's European Union Minister Jaume Duch; members of the Spanish Congress Andrea Fernández and Jon Iñarritu; State Attorney Edmundo Bal Francés; Juan González-Barba, former secretary of state for the European Union ...

And more ... Daniel Calleja y Crespo, head of the European Commission Representation in Spain; María Andrés, head of the European Parliament Office in Spain; Ukraine's Ambassador to Spain Yuliia Sokolovska; Canadian Ambassador Jeffrey Marder; German Ambassador Heiko Thoms; British Ambassador Alex Ellis; North Macedonia's Ambassador Edmond Ademi; Andorran Ambassador Eva Descarrega; Australian Ambassador Rosemary Morris-Castico; Ana Palacio, former minister of foreign

affairs of Spain ...

And breathe ... Qualcomm Vice President of Government Affairs Audrey Scozzaro Ferrazzini; Uber's Vice President and Head of EMEA Rides Anabel Díaz Calderón and Regional General Manager for Iberia Felipe Fernández Aramburu; Banco Santander Head of Communications Planning and Strategy Jorge Zuloaga; Naturgy's Director of International Public Affairs David Gallardo; Spanish Banking Association President Alejandra Kindelán; AmChamSpain Chair Jaime Malet; beBartlet co-founder Adrián Jofre Bosch; Harmon partner Borja Bergareche and President Carmen Basagoiti; Rud Pedersen Spain Managing Partner Diego Sanjuanbenito; Rasmussen Global CEO Fabrice Pothier; Bank of America's Francisco Blanch; Newgate Spain CEO Javier de Mendizabal; New Economy Forum President José Luis Rodríguez; Agencia EFE Chief Editor Enrique Rubio; Enrique Lavilla, editor-in-chief of El Español; Netflix Senior Communications Manager Rut Rey; and POLITICO's CEO Goli Sheikholeslami, Senior Executive Editor for Europe Kate Day, Chief Commercial Officer Cally Baute, Senior Editor for Spain Ángel Villarino and Deputy Editor for Spain Kike Andrés-Pretel.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz and his coalition partners meet to talk about the budget and reforms today, but the relationship between parties is getting increasingly fraught.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron is stepping in to take control of the student protests, but France's government has plenty of other problems piling up, with its budget under scrutiny and farmers waiting for a recovery plan.

London: Kemi Badenoch will appeal to British voters to back the Conservatives instead of Nigel Farage's Reform UK when she addresses her party's annual conference today .

Washington: One of the messiest Senate races in the country is getting even messier, as Republican Susan Collins tries to distance herself from the White House.

Ottawa: Canada's trade surplus with the U.S. just got a Trump bump , posting its "largest positive monthly change ever."

Canberra: A parliamentary inquiry is drilling down into the hidden costs of AI , suggesting that workers, infrastructure and some businesses are already being squeezed.

AGENDA

— Coreper I meets at 9 a.m. Coreper II meets at 10 a.m.

— The Political and Security Committee meets at 10:30 a.m.

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa participate in the MED9 Summit of Southern EU countries in Split, Croatia.

— U.K. European Relations Minister Hamish Falconer meets European Parliament President Roberta Metsola and Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič.

— The European Parliament debates the EU's next long-term budget for 2028-2034 from 9 a.m. (watch live).

- Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos has an exchange of views with the Parliament's Committee on Foreign Affairs (AFET) at 8 a.m. Watch live .
- Metsola receives European Court of Auditors President Tony Murphy at 5 p.m. during Parliament's plenary session in Strasbourg.
- EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas visits Lebanon.
- Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius gives keynote speech at the Military Schengen 2026 Conference in Hamburg, Germany at 1:30 p.m. Watch live .
- Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen meets French Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu.
- Šefčovič holds a call with Malaysian Investment, Trade and Industry Minister Johari Abdul Ghani.
- Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica meets Portuguese Foreign Minister Paulo Rangel in Split.
- Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque delivers a speech at a BusinessEurope and European Banking Federation event on EU banking competitiveness.
- Renew Europe MEP Hilde Vautmans, rapporteur on EU-China political relations, holds a press conference at 3 p.m. (watch live).

BIRTHDAYS

Socialists and Democrats President Iratxe García; former MEPs Phil Bennion and Jean Arthuis; ECIPE's Hosuk Lee-Makiyama; POLITICO alum and Managing Editor for EU Politics at Contexte Anca Gurzu; Vertige Media's Matthieu Amaré; Russian President Vladimir Putin.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

******A message from Amazon: Founded to support the digital evolution of farming, xFarm uses the AWS Cloud to power a platform that helps farmers improve productivity while keeping sustainability at the core of their operations. By turning agricultural data into actionable insights, xFarm enables farmers to make smarter decisions in an increasingly complex environmental and economic landscape. "With the AWS Cloud, we can connect farms around the world, transforming agriculture through innovation while keeping sustainability at the heart of everything we do," says Giovanni Causapruno of xFarm. xFarm is one of many European businesses building on the AWS Cloud to operate at scale, strengthen resilience, and support more sustainable food systems. The AWS Cloud helps xFarm extend its impact across borders—supporting farmers as they adapt to today's environmental and operational challenges. Learn more about how businesses across Europe are growing with the AWS Cloud at [AWS.eu](https://aws.amazon.com/eu). ******

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